

Purple Leaf Plum

Prunus cerasifera



Origin

Native to southeastern Europe and western Asia (the wild species is *Prunus cerasifera*); purple-leaved ornamental varieties were selectively bred and became popular street and yard trees in the 20th century.

Look for

Like Crimson King maple, its purple color is present all season rather than just in fall -- a useful way to distinguish it from ordinary green-leaved cherry or plum trees at a glance.

IDENTIFICATION TIPS

- Leaf: purple-red, oval, football-shaped, present all season.
- Flower: pale pink, blooms before or alongside emerging leaves.
- Size: compact, small-statured tree.
- Commonly confused with: Crimson King maple (this species' leaves are oval and smaller, not maple-shaped).

THROUGH THE SEASONS

Spring	Pale pink flowers bloom before or alongside the emerging purple leaves.
Summer	Deep purple-red foliage stands out against green neighboring trees.
Fall	Color deepens slightly before leaves drop, without a big color change.
Winter	Smooth bark with lenticel dashes on a compact, rounded form.

DID YOU KNOW

- It's a compact, small-statured tree, which made it a popular choice for smaller city tree pits and yards where a large shade tree wouldn't fit.
- Its spring flowers, which open before most of the purple leaves, briefly turn the whole tree a soft pink before the leaf color takes over.